MANCHESTER UNITED ANALYTICS PORTFOLIO | PUBLIC DATA | MAY 6, 2026

Casemiro Replacement Profile

The next signing should not only win duels. It should prevent some of them from happening.

Executive View

This is a recruitment screen, not a signing verdict. It translates United's need for control into a repeatable public-data framework.

TOP WEIGHTED SCREEN

Exequiel Palacios

Bayer Leverkusen | score 74.8 | age 27

PUBLISHED CONTROL PROFILES

2 players

Gated shortlist candidates with possession-security score of 70+. These profiles help United reduce repeat emergency defending.

DEFENSIVE REFERENCE

4 players

Priority candidates above Casemiro's defensive-protection reference score.

Interpretation: Palacios should be read as the strongest possession-control candidate in the screen, not as the strongest like-for-like Casemiro replacement. He leads the screen subject to availability and injury-history review. Cardoso is the cleaner two-axis defensive/security fit.

Reference	Age	Defence	Transition	Security	Progression
Manuel Ugarte	25	84.17	57.14	72.14	15.00
Casemiro	34	63.33	12.86	15.00	25.00

How The Score Works

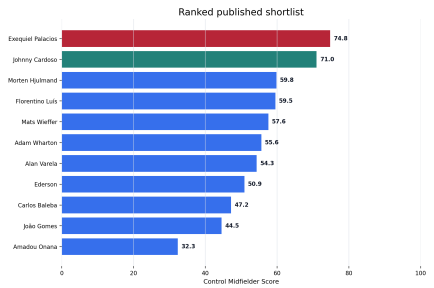
Each player receives five category scores. Those categories are weighted into a single Control Midfielder Score.

DEFENSIVE PROTECTION	TRANSITION CONTROL	POSSESSION SECURITY	PROGRESSIVE VALUE	AGE / AVAILABILITY
30%	**25%**	**25%**	**15%**	**5%**
6 input metrics. Category score is the average of percentile-style metric scores.	7 input metrics. Category score is the average of percentile-style metric scores.	7 input metrics. Category score is the average of percentile-style metric scores.	6 input metrics. Category score is the average of percentile-style metric scores.	2 input metrics. Category score is the average of percentile-style metric scores.

Plain English: A 100 does not mean world class. It means the player is high relative to this screened public-data pool. Negative events such as fouls, cards, miscontrols, dispossessions, and turnover rate are inverted so safer players score better.

1. Ranked Shortlist

The published shortlist applies a light defensive-protection gate to remove pure control profiles with limited ball-winning evidence. The gate is intentionally low because the model is screening for complementary control midfielders, not only defensive destroyers.



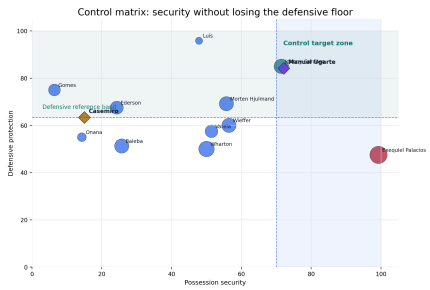
How to read it

- The bar length is the final weighted score, not a direct scouting grade.
- Palacios rises because possession security and progression matter heavily in the brief.
- Cardoso's lower total still matters because his defensive floor is much stronger.

#	Player	Club	League	Age	Score	Defence	Transition	Security	Progression	Age/Avail.
1	Exequiel Palacios	Bayer Leverkusen	Bundesliga	27	74.77	47.50	79.29	99.29	85.83	60.00
2	Johnny Cardoso	Atletico Madrid	La Liga	24	71.00	85.00	63.57	71.43	57.50	62.50
3	Morten Hjulmand	Sporting CP	Primeira Liga	26	59.82	69.17	51.07	55.71	55.00	82.50
4	Florentino Luís	Burnley	Premier League	26	59.54	95.83	59.29	47.86	8.33	55.00
5	Mats Wieffer	Brighton & Hove Albion	Premier League	26	57.57	60.00	52.86	56.43	55.83	77.50
6	Adam Wharton	Crystal Palace	Premier League	22	55.61	50.00	61.43	50.00	67.50	52.50
7	Alan Varela	Porto	Primeira Liga	24	54.32	57.50	57.86	51.43	42.50	67.50
8	Ederson	Atalanta	Serie A	26	50.91	67.50	52.86	24.29	45.00	92.50
9	Carlos Baleba	Brighton & Hove Albion	Premier League	22	47.17	51.25	50.71	25.71	55.83	86.25
10	João Gomes	Wolverhampton Wanderers	Premier League	25	44.55	75.00	44.29	6.43	35.83	80.00
11	Amadou Onana	Aston Villa	Premier League	24	32.32	55.00	25.00	14.29	16.67	70.00

2. Control Matrix

This chart shows the main football trade-off: can the player help United control possession without losing the defensive floor?

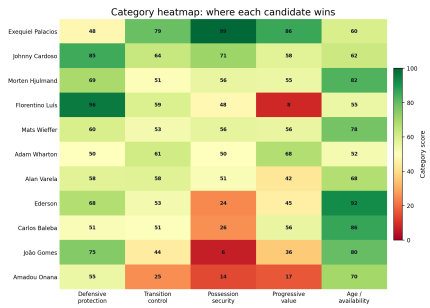


Scout and fan read

- Right side means safer possession: more secure receiving, passing, and turnover profile.
- Higher up means stronger defensive protection relative to the pool.
- Bigger bubbles add more progressive value: they help United move forward, not just recycle.

3. Category Heatmap

The heatmap explains why players with similar total scores can be very different midfielders.



What the colors mean

- Green means a strength relative to the screened public-data pool.
- Red does not automatically rule a player out; it tells the scout what to test on video.
- Florentino is a defensive specialist, while Palacios and Stiller are clearer control/pass profiles.

4. Casemiro and Ugarte References

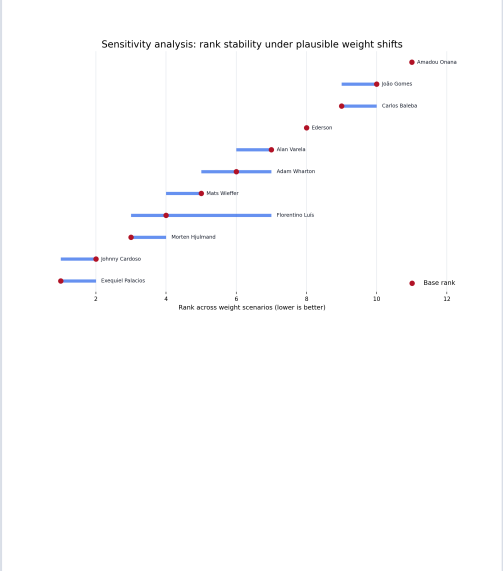
United's current midfield references help explain the target brief: preserve the ball-winning base, but add more control and progression.

Why this matters

- Casemiro is the ageing reference point for defensive responsibility, not the statistical clone target.
- Ugarte already covers much of the defensive/security need.
- The next midfielder should complement that base by adding cleaner possession and progression.

5. Sensitivity and Practicality

A good screen should not collapse when reasonable category weights move.



What to look for

- Stable names are less dependent on one subjective weighting choice.
- Age, minutes, and market value are only practical context fields.
- Final decisions still need video, tactical role fit, medical, contract, and fee work.

Watchlist: Removed By Defensive Gate

These players remain analytically interesting, but they do not clear the light defensive-protection threshold used for the published shortlist.

Player	Club	Score	Defence	Main Risk	Risk Score
Elliot Anderson	Nottingham Forest	62.66	42.50	defensive_protection	42.50
Angelo Stiller	Stuttgart	57.68	8.33	defensive_protection	8.33
Hugo Larsson	Eintracht Frankfurt	55.29	38.75	defensive_protection	38.75
Aleix Garcia	Bayer Leverkusen	54.14	6.67	defensive_protection	6.67
Samuele Ricci	AC Milan	50.23	28.75	defensive_protection	28.75
Bruno Guimarães	Newcastle United	48.86	27.50	defensive_protection	27.50
Youssouf Fofana	AC Milan	39.15	36.25	possession_security	20.71

Limitations

The strongest version of this project is honest about what public data can and cannot prove.

What this does well

It turns an abstract United need, "more control", into measurable screening traits: defensive protection, transition control,

What it cannot do

It cannot replace club scouting. StatsBomb open data is limited to selected competitions, public aggregate stats are not proprietary club data, and public statsbombpy

possession security, progression, and age/availability.

repeatable transparent portfolio-ready

access should not be treated as 360 data access.

Built with pandas, matplotlib, seaborn, StatsBomb open-data role logic, and FBref-style/public aggregate player statistics. This is a screening framework, not a final recruitment decision model.